

Palau



A republic in the western Pacific consisting of more than 300 islands, of which only nine are inhabited.

1500s Palau colonized by Spain, which only acquires full sovereignty in 1886.

1899 Spain sells Palau to Germany.

1914 Japan occupies Palau.

1921 League of Nations grants a mandate over Palau to Japan.

1944 US troops occupy Palau near the end of World War II.

1947 UN Trust Territory of the Pacific Islands—including Palau—is established.

1979 Palau votes against joining the new Federated States of Micronesia and becomes autonomous in 1981.

1982 Palau signs Compact of Free Association with the US.

1994 Palau becomes independent in free association with the US.

2006 Government moves to new capital Melekeok.

2009 Palau accepts six Chinese ethnic Uighurs freed from Guantanamo Bay.

◀216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Micronesia



Micronesia comprises the former Caroline Islands—except Palau—in the western Pacific.

1500s Islands colonized by Spain.

1899 Spain sells the islands to Germany.

1914 At start of World War I, Japan occupies Caroline Islands.

1920 League of Nations grants a mandate over the islands to Japan.

1945 US troops occupy the Caroline Islands at the end of World War II.

1947 UN Trust Territory of the Pacific Islands—including the Caroline Islands—is established, administered by the US.

1979 Federated States of Micronesia is formed.

1986 A compact of Free Association with the US becomes operational as the islands gain independence.

2004 Nearly all of Yap's infrastructure is destroyed by Typhoon Sudal.

◀216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Nauru



The island nation of Nauru is the world's smallest republic, with only 12,570 inhabitants.

1798 Earlier colonized by Melanesians and Polynesians, Nauru is discovered by British navigator Captain John Fearn.

1888 Nauru is annexed by Germany.

1900 Phosphate is found on the island; extraction begins in 1906 in a joint UK–German venture.

1914 Nauru is captured by Australian forces at the start of World War I.

1920 League of Nations mandate places Nauru under control of Australia, New Zealand, and the UK, with the island's administration conducted by Australia.

1942 The Japanese occupy Nauru. More than a thousand islanders are deported to Truk in Micronesia where 500 die from bombing and starvation.

1945 Nauru is occupied by Allied troops.

1947 Australia, New Zealand, and UK administer Nauru under UN trusteeship.

1968 Nauru gains independence.

1970 Gains control of phosphate industry.

1993 Australia and UK agree to provide compensation for environmental damage caused by phosphate extraction.

1999 Joins UN.

2001 As the phosphate runs out, the island relies on Australian aid, agreeing to hold Australian asylum seekers. Nauru's offshore banks are closed after US allegations of money laundering.

2004 State of emergency is declared after parliament fails to pass the budget.

2008 Australia halts its policy of sending asylum seekers to Nauru.

2010 Referendum rejects proposed changes to the constitution.

◀216–17 Polynesian Expansion



Nauru, world's smallest republic
The tiny island republic is almost circular, with a 10-mile (16-km) ring road around the outside. Everyone lives on the narrow coastal strip, as the interior is uninhabitable former mining land.

Marshall Islands



A collection of 34 widely scattered atolls in the central Pacific, of which 24 are inhabited.

1788 British explorer John Marshall visits the islands, giving them their name.

1886 Islands become a German colony.

1914 Japan occupies the islands and governs them after 1920 under a League of Nations mandate.

1944 US troops occupy the islands and use them from 1946 for nuclear tests.

1946 First nuclear test at Bikini Atoll. Tests continue until 1958.

1986 Compact of Free Association with US as the islands become independent. The UN trust is ended in 1990.

2001 Compensation to the people of Bikini Atoll for the damage caused by US nuclear testing is agreed to in principle.

2008 A state of emergency is declared as waves flood major urban centers.

◀216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Kiribati



One half of the former Gilbert & Ellice Islands, Kiribati is pronounced "Keer-ee-bus."

1605 The Spanish explorer, Quiros, sights one of the islands in Kiribati, already inhabited by Micronesian people.

1892 The British establish a protectorate over the phosphate-producing Gilbert & Ellice Islands.

1916 The Gilbert & Ellice Islands are declared a British colony.

1942–43 The Gilbert Islands are occupied by the Japanese. Tarawa Atoll is the site of a fierce battle between US and Japanese troops.

1957 First British nuclear tests take place near Christmas Island (now Kiritimati).

1979 Independence as two states: Kiribati (the Gilberts) and Tuvalu (the Ellices).

1981 Kiribati wins damages for phosphate mining from UK.

1986 Kiribati signs lucrative fishing deal with the US in return for aid.

2002 Announces legal action against US for environmental problems stemming from US refusal to sign Kyoto Protocol.

◀216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Solomon Islands



A large archipelago scattered over the western Pacific; most islands are coral reefs.

1568 Spanish first make contact with the islands, which are inhabited by Melanesian people.

1893 UK makes the southern Solomons a protectorate, adding further islands in 1898–99, and acquiring some northern islands from Germany in 1900.

1942–43 During Japanese occupation, a lengthy battle with US forces takes place around Guadalcanal Island.

1978 Independence from UK.

1998 Ethnic conflict between Guadalcanal and Malaita islanders as 20,000 Malaitans are forced from their homes on Guadalcanal by native militias. In 2000 Malaita rebels stage an unsuccessful coup and hold the prime minister at gunpoint for two days.

2003 After further ethnic conflict, an Australian-led Regional Assistance Mission arrives to restore order and reform the country's chaotic finances.

2005 Harold Keke, a leader of an anti-Malaitan militia in the 1998–2003 Guadalcanal conflict, is convicted of the 2002 murder of an MP.

2009 A Truth and Reconciliation Commission is established to investigate fighting between ethnic militias on Guadalcanal in 1998–2003.

◀216–17 Polynesian Expansion

Vanuatu



A sprawling archipelago of 82 islands in the South Pacific, of which only 12 are of any size.

1605 The Spanish explorer, Quiros, visits the islands.

1800s The Melanesian inhabitants are visited by European missionaries and merchants seeking to cut the sandalwood trees. Cotton planters follow.

1906 In response to calls from Australia to annex the islands, the UK and France agree on joint rule of the New Hebrides, as they are now called.

1938 The John Frum cargo cult emerges, promising the return of goods "stolen by foreigners." Its leaders are jailed, but in 1956 it is recognized as a religion.

1980 Independence as the Republic of Vanuatu. The name means "Our Land Forever." The northern island of Espiritu Santo attempts to secede.